

A Guideline-Based Approach for Creating Personalized Storybooks with Generative AI

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Abstract—Children’s storybooks have traditionally used generic themes, but even with generative AI enabling non-experts to create personalized versions, challenges remain in ensuring quality and supporting parents. To address this, we devised *revision guidelines for parents* for two modalities: text and images. We conducted a study with 20 parents, where they were asked to create personalized storybooks for their children and share their feedback. We identified distinct challenges across the modalities such as checking for age-inappropriate language when generating a story with texts, resolving limited rendering of the details for the illustration. However, in general, participants valued the revision guide as perceived as useful for quality improvement. Based on the results, we offer insights for future AI-assisted storytelling tools for guiding non-expert parents toward creating high-quality storybook for their children.

Index Terms—personalized book, generative AI, guidelines, human-ai collaboration

I. INTRODUCTION

Parent-child storybook reading is a foundational practice in early childhood, yet providing such experiences requires substantial effort from parents, including the selection and storage of appropriate books [1], [2]. In addition, children’s storybooks have traditionally been created around fixed topics and non-personalized content, limiting their ability to reflect the individual characteristics and needs of young readers [3], [4]. In response, there has been increasing attention to personalized books for children [5]–[8]. Early childhood is a critical period for identity formation and self-expression, during which personalized storybooks can foster positive parent–child interaction, language and attention engagement, and broader cognitive and linguistic development [5], [9], [10].

However, because young children have limited language and cognitive abilities, parental involvement is essential in creating personalized storybooks. Yet, as non-experts, most parents find the process demanding, since topic selection, narrative construction, and illustration design require specialized skills that are difficult to manage without professional knowledge [11], [12].

Within this context, the recent rise of generative AI has emerged as a potential tool to alleviate these challenges [6]. A variety of AI-based story creation platforms targeting parents and children have been introduced, many of which support multimodal content generation, including text, and images for

personalized narratives [13]–[16]. Nevertheless, while generative AI has reduced some of the difficulties in storybook creation, important gaps remain. In particular, there is limited understanding of how parents and AI should contribute to stages of personalized storybook creation and what kinds of support parents need when revising AI-generated content [17].

To address this gap, we examine how parents and AI contribute to the creation of personalized storybooks. We introduce and evaluate *revision guidelines for parents* that support systematic revision of AI-generated text and images.

We conducted a study with 20 parents of children aged 12–36 months. Participants used AI to create personalized storybooks across text and image modalities and revised the generated outputs with or without revision guidelines. The finalized storybooks were assembled into e-book form using a custom web platform developed for this study.

Our results show that while AI was useful for generating personalized content, parents frequently revised the outputs to improve narrative coherence, age-appropriate language, visual quality, and consistency across modalities. Based on these results, we identify implications for the design of AI-assisted storybook creation systems.

In summary, this work extends existing research on storybook generation [18] and human–AI co-creation [19], [20] by exploring guideline design in AI-assisted storybook creation.

Our contributions are the following:

- The examination of the division of roles between parents and AI in supporting the story creation process
- The analysis of how the provision of guidelines influences both the quality of outcomes and the direction of parental revisions

II. RELATED WORK

A. AI-Powered Tools for Narrative Creation

Recent advances in generative artificial intelligence (AI) and large language models (LLMs) have led to the rapid development of tools that support narrative creation. These tools report benefits such as enhancing imagination and literacy, providing personalized reading experiences, and fostering emotional engagement and parental support [6], [21]–[24]. They take diverse forms, including systems that generate narratives from photos, speech, or keywords; frameworks

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that design storybooks using readability indices; applications that integrate children’s names and interests; and multi-modal platforms that encourage co-reading with parents. Building on these developments, recent work introduces conversational AI agents that scaffold parent–child picturebook co-creation, improving engagement and comprehension [25]–[27]. However, existing studies remain limited in narrative coherence, alignment with learning goals, and long-term validation, and offer insufficient personalization and adaptive scaffolding [22], [23], [25], [26]. To address these gaps, this study focuses on identifying the standards necessary for non-expert parents to create AI-assisted storybooks that are both high in quality and reflective of their children’s characteristics and preferences.

B. Humans as Curators, AI as Generators

Humans and AI offer complementary strengths in content creation. AI can rapidly generate novel contents, yet its outputs are often repetitive with limited capacity to account for children’s developmental, emotional, and ethical needs [28], [29]. Human involvement is therefore essential for setting educational intent, ensuring thematic focus, and expanding meaning. Prior work shows that explainable AI fosters trust in human–AI collaboration, while human feedback and complementarity enhance AI performance more than what AI or human could achieve alone [30]–[32].

Since high-quality storybooks require clarity, consistency, human revision and curation remain essential to ensure that AI-generated content is calibrated in difficulty and aligned with children’s educational and emotional needs [17], [22]. Nonetheless, evidence also indicates that while human–AI collaboration excels in creative domains, it may introduce drawbacks in decision-making tasks, underscoring the need for tailored structures and evaluation metrics for effective partnership [33]. Thus, this study explores a collaboration structure in which AI functions as the generator of storybook content, and parents act as curators who review and finalize the AI-generated results.

III. METHOD

To examine parental challenges, role division between parents and AI, and the effects of guidelines on storybook revision, we conducted a between-subjects experiment with two conditions. The session comprised two stages: (1) text generation and revision, and (2) image generation and revision based on the revised text.

A. Conditions

Participants were randomly assigned to one of two conditions, with 10 participants in each condition:

- *None*: Participants revised AI-generated text and images without revision guidelines.
- *Guidelines*: Participants revised AI-generated text and images with revision guidelines.

The revision guidelines were designed to support parents in refining both story text and accompanying images by considering not only narrative content but also visual elements.

Text Revision Guidelines for Parents

You can review the following points and make any desired edits yourself without ChatGPT assistance:

1. Story Title

- Is the title related to your child’s interests or favorite things? (e.g., dinosaurs, space, dogs, cars, etc.)
- If not, what title could be changed to make the story more engaging for your child?

2. Chapter-by-Chapter Check

- Does each chapter flow naturally from the previous one? If not, revise it so that it flows smoothly.
- Is the storyline interesting and aligned with your child’s interests? If not, add or adjust content to match their preferences.
- Does the last sentence leave a warm feeling or a sense of closure?

3. Overall Check

- Does the story include elements your child will enjoy (characters, actions, speech)?
- If your child’s role is too minor or underemphasized, revise to make your child more central.
- Are there any words or sentences that are too difficult or long for your child to understand? If so, replace them with simpler words or shorter sentences.
- Is the story flow smooth overall?
- When reading the entire story, is it likely to be enjoyable for your child? If not, adjust the text to better suit their preferences.
- Does the story convey the intended message (e.g., courage, friendship, love)?
- Check for any content that your child might find scary or unpleasant. If present, remove it.

Fig. 1. Text revision guideline for Parent

The guidelines served as a cross-checking mechanism for elements that were not fully reflected in the AI-generated outputs, enabling parents to incorporate multimodal cues more consistently into the final personalized storybook.

B. Revision Guidelines for Parents

We provided parents in *Guidelines* group with revision guidelines as you can see in Fig. 1 and Fig. 2. For each modality (text and image), parents reviewed the guidelines, identified aspects to modify, and determined how to implement the desired changes. Text revision guidelines were applied when revising without ChatGPT, whereas the image revision guideline was used in conjunction with ChatGPT.

C. Participants

Eligibility criteria for participation were: (1) being a primary caregiver (e.g., parent or grandparent) who provided daily care for a child at least five days a week, and (2) having a child between 12 and 36 months of age, referred to as toddlers in this study. The latter criterion was based on prior work suggesting that providing personalized books to children aged 12–36 months enhances parent-child interaction [5], [34].

Twenty parents participated in the study (3 fathers, 17 mothers; age 28–43 years, $M = 34.6$, $SD = 3.98$). Their children ranged in age from 11 months and 16 days to 36 months and 11 days ($M = 23.5$ months, $SD = 9.34$), including 4 boys and 16 girls. Parents reported that their children had no

Image Revision Guidelines for Parents

Please refer to the following points when requesting ChatGPT to make specific edits:

1. Chapter-by-Chapter Check

- Does the story of each chapter translate well into the illustration?
- Do the characters' expressions, actions, and background match the scene?
- Can the child recall the story just by looking at the illustration?

2. Character Details

- Are your child's unique features clearly represented?
- Are aspects like skin tone, hairstyle, glasses, clothing, and eye color accurately reflected?
- Are your child's frequently worn clothes or favorite accessories included?
- Are there any features you want to adjust to make the character more like your child? Be specific. (e.g., make the hair curlier, change red sneakers to blue sneakers)

3. Mood / Style

- Is the color palette and overall style soft and warm?
- Make sure there are no frightening art styles or overly dark backgrounds.
- Does the illustration reflect your child's preferred style and mood? (e.g., make the character cuter, make the background brighter)
- You can also request favorite colors to be included (e.g., add pink tones to the background).

4. Overall Check

- Does the composition of characters and background work well in each scene?
- Are characters too small, or are important parts of the scene not visible?
- Are the illustration styles consistent across all scenes?
- Is the child's appearance as represented by the character drawn consistently throughout?

Fig. 2. Image revision guideline for Parent

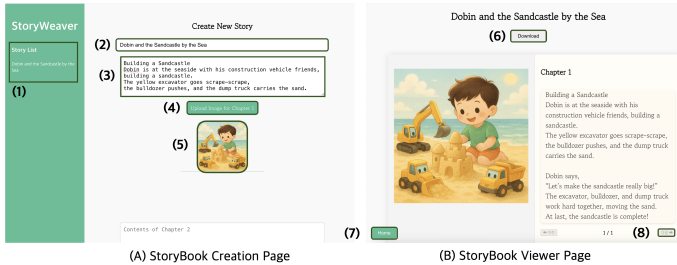


Fig. 3. User Interface of our custom website. (1) displays the list of completed stories. (2) provides a text area for entering the storybook title, while (3) provides a text area for composing the storybook content. (4) allows users to upload an image for Chapter 1, and (5) displays the uploaded image. On the finalized story page, users can download the completed story at (6), return to the upload page by clicking (7) and proceed to the next chapter of the story by clicking (8).

physical or developmental conditions. All participants received compensation for their time.

D. Experiment Settings

To collect child-related information for personalized storybook creation, we used a Google Form. Initial story text was generated in advance to reduce the duration of the story creation and review session. All sessions were conducted

via Google Meet. In this study, we employed ChatGPT-5 to generate the initial creative content across modalities, including story text and illustrative images.

To support participants in creating personalized storybooks, we developed a custom web platform (Fig. 3) that supports multilingual and multimodal story creation. The platform was implemented in React and deployed via GitHub Pages. Within the platform, finalized text and images selected and revised by participants were integrated into a completed storybook, which served as the final output of the study.

E. Procedure

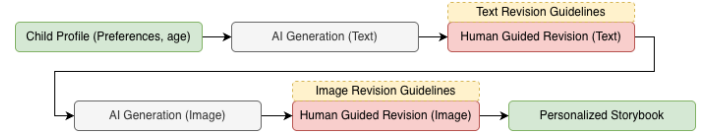


Fig. 4. Overview of the storybook creation process used in the experiment. The process consists of five stages: (1) text generation with AI, (2) text revision, (3) image generation with AI, (4) image revision, and (5) final storybook review. AI models generate the initial content, while parents revise the generated text and images using revision guidelines.

The experiment consisted of five stages, as shown in Fig. 4: (1) AI-based text generation based on the child's age and preferences, (2) text revision, (3) AI-based image generation based on the revised text, (4) image revision, and (5) final storybook review.

For text generation, participants used a prompt such as: "Based on the following conditions, write a three-chapter storybook" followed by the child's age and preferences. For image generation, they used a prompt such as: "Based on the given story content and the following elements, generate an image that best represents each chapter."

Depending on the experimental condition, participants revised text and images either with or without revision guidelines, as shown in Fig. 1 and Fig. 2. During the revision stages, participants were free to modify the generated text and images.

IV. RESULTS

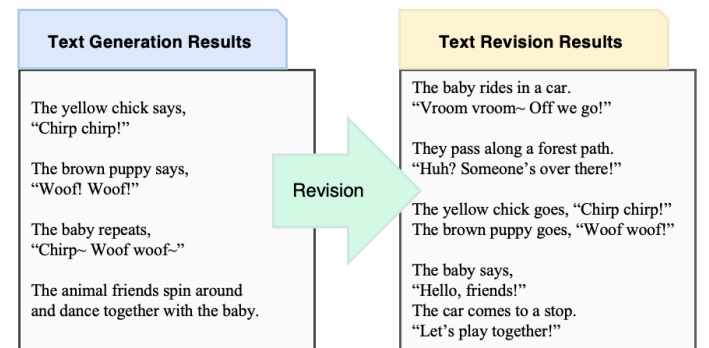


Fig. 5. An example of generated and the final revised texts from P19 in Guidelines group.

TABLE I
PERCEIVED USEFULNESS OF TEXT AND IMAGE REVISION GUIDELINES
(MEAN AND STANDARD DEVIATION).

Group	Text Guideline Usefulness	Image Guideline Usefulness
None	—	—
Guidelines	6.2 (0.79)	5.7 (1.25)

TABLE II
PERCEIVED USEFULNESS OF AI FOR STORYBOOK CREATION AND
INTENTION TO USE AI IN THE FUTURE.

Group	Perceived Usefulness of AI (Mean (SD))	Future Use Intention (N)
None	5.9 (1.37)	6
Guidelines	6.8 (0.42)	9

A. The Assessment of Text Revision

1) *Text Revision Tendency*: Most participants ($N = 17$) revised the generated texts. During revision, participants primarily focused on improving plausibility and structural coherence ($N = 6$) and enhancing personalization for their children ($N = 6$). Other considerations included content accuracy and consistency ($N = 5$), interaction design ($N = 4$), and language level and rhythm ($N = 3$). Participants who were provided with guideline support tended to focus more on improving overall coherence and structure. In contrast, those without such support emphasized incorporating children’s traits and interactive elements.

2) *Text Revision Guidelines’ Assessment*: Fig. 5 illustrates an example of text revision, where the initial generated text is refined to improve narrative coherence and detail based on the guideline. Participants in the *Guidelines* group were asked to evaluate the usefulness of the text revision guidelines (see Fig. 1). The most frequently reported benefit was improved problem recognition ($N = 4$), indicating that participants often identified issues only after consulting the guidelines. Other benefits included the need for human verification ($N = 2$) and improvements in narrative quality ($N = 2$), particularly in terms of coherence and message clarity.

Overall, the guidelines supported fine-grained revisions, such as adjusting tone and improving narrative flow. However, some participants found certain aspects less useful. For example, several participants ($N = 4$) noted that checking the title was unnecessary, as it was already addressed during AI generation or not considered critical.

Participants also expressed differing views on guideline constraints. Some noted that filtering potentially negative content might not be necessary, while others felt that child preferences were already sufficiently specified in the initial prompts. These responses suggest that certain guideline components may become redundant when prompts are sufficiently detailed.

As shown in Table I, participants reported relatively high perceived usefulness of the text revision guidelines, with mean scores of 6.2 ($SD = 0.79$).

B. The Assessment of Image Revision

1) *Image Revision Tendency*: During image revision, participants most frequently emphasized strengthening content ($N = 6$) and improving drawing style ($N = 5$). Other considerations included error correction ($N = 4$), and enhancing consistency and detail ($N = 4$). Participants in the *Guidelines* group tended to emphasize correcting specific elements based on the provided criteria. In contrast, those without guideline support focused more on overall stylistic consistency and general refinement. Participants reported perceived usefulness of the image revision guidelines, with mean scores of 5.7 ($SD = 1.25$) as illustrated in Table I.

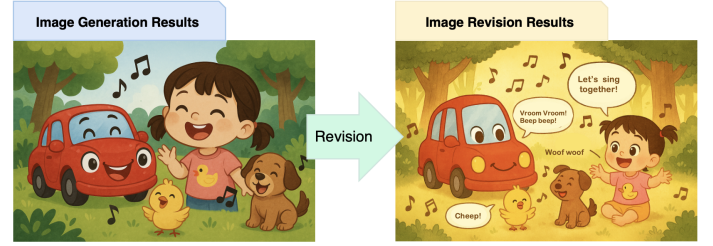


Fig. 6. An example of generated and the final revised image from P19 in *Guidelines* group.

2) *Assessment of Image Revision Guidelines*: Fig. 6 illustrates an example of image revision, where the initial generated image is refined to include additional contextual details and multimodal elements (e.g., sound expressions and dialogue) based on the guideline. Participants in the *Guidelines* group ($N = 10$) evaluated the usefulness of the image revision guidelines (see Fig. 2). Several participants reported that the guidelines helped ensure alignment between images and story content, particularly for subtle elements such as emotional expressions. Others noted that example-based instructions facilitated more precise prompting.

In addition, some participants described the guidelines as a form of validation, allowing them to confirm aspects they already considered important ($N = 2$). The guidelines also supported personalization, such as adapting characters to resemble their own children.

However, some elements were perceived as redundant. Participants ($N = 3$) reported that aspects such as character details and visual style were already sufficiently reflected in the initial AI outputs. Others noted limitations, including a lack of concrete examples for certain revisions and overly restrictive constraints that could reduce visual detail. These findings suggest the need for more flexible and example-driven guideline design.

C. Perception of AI and Future Use Intention

Participants generally perceived AI as helpful for storybook creation. As reported in Table II, the perceived helpfulness score was higher in the *Guidelines* group ($M = 6.8$, $SD = 0.42$) compared to the *None* group ($M = 5.9$, $SD = 1.37$), suggesting that guideline support may enhance users’ evaluation of AI.

Similarly, willingness to use AI for future storybook creation was high in both groups. Table II shows that 9 out of 10 participants in the *Guidelines* group and 6 out of 10 in the *None* group indicated positive intention, suggesting that guideline support may positively influence adoption intention.

V. DISCUSSION

A. AI Potential and the Irreplaceable Role of Human Oversight

1) *Complementary Roles of AI and Parents:* In this study, AI primarily generated initial multi-modal content, while participants reviewed, corrected, and refined these outputs to ensure developmental appropriateness, consistency, and engagement. This finding aligns with prior work [7], which highlights a clear division of roles between AI and human collaborators. Similarly, our results indicate that effective personalized story creation relies on collaborative interaction between AI and parents. AI was particularly effective in rapidly generating ideas, producing structurally coherent drafts, and incorporating children’s preferences [6].

However, these strengths alone were insufficient to ensure developmental appropriateness and contextual validity. As noted in prior work [35], parents played a critical role in evaluating age appropriateness, adapting content to specific contexts, and tailoring stories to individual children. These findings suggest that high-quality outcomes emerge through human–AI collaboration rather than either acting alone.

2) *Risks and Limitations of AI-Generated Content:* Several risks and limitations were observed during the initial storybook creation process. AI-generated content occasionally included developmentally inappropriate elements or factual inaccuracies, while initial image generation produced inconsistencies in visual details such as character appearance across scenes [36]. In addition, some participants showed overreliance on AI outputs, accepting them without critical evaluation even when errors were present. These findings highlight the need for mechanisms that support critical evaluation of AI outputs.

To address these issues, structured review mechanisms, such as checklist-based verification of content appropriateness, and technical constraints, such as attribute consistency controls, may be beneficial. Prompting strategies that require justification or reflection may further encourage critical engagement. These results emphasize the importance of human-in-the-loop approaches, where AI outputs are evaluated and refined.

3) *The Trade-off Between Efficiency and Quality:* A key finding of this study is the trade-off between efficiency and quality in AI-assisted storybook creation. On one hand, AI enabled non-experts to produce personalized stories quickly and at low cost by automating key aspects of narrative generation. On the other hand, compared with professionally authored storybooks, AI-generated content often lacked narrative coherence, fine-grained detail, and originality [37].

Participants in the *Guidelines* group, reported greater difficulty across multiple aspects of the task. The presence of guideline appeared to increase expectations for quality while also introducing additional cognitive load. As a result, this

pattern may be interpreted as indicating lower satisfaction and higher perceived difficulty among participants.

This pattern is further supported by findings that participants identified issues in the story through the revision guidelines, which itself required additional cognitive effort. These results highlight the challenge of balancing efficiency and quality, and suggest the need for careful system design to manage this trade-off.

B. Limitations

This study has several limitations. The provision of guidelines, while designed to facilitate the creative process, sometimes raised participants’ expectations for the completeness of the outputs. At the same time, the need to reflect on additional considerations embedded in the guidelines increased their cognitive load, which in turn could undermine satisfaction and amplify perceptions of difficulty. Careful attention is therefore needed to design guidelines that enhance efficiency without inadvertently overwhelming users. Moreover, our results are bounded by the use of a single model, ChatGPT. Although this choice provided stable and accessible performance, it also risks anchoring the outcomes to the specific characteristics of one model. Comparative evaluations across different models will be necessary to establish the robustness and generalizability of these insights.

VI. CONCLUSION

This study examined how parents and AI collaborate in creating personalized storybooks across text and image modalities. Through a between-subjects study with parents of children aged 12–36 months, we explored how parents revised AI-generated story content with and without revision guidelines.

Our results suggest that although AI was effective in generating personalized content, parents played an essential role in improving narrative coherence, selecting age-appropriate language, refining image quality, and maintaining consistency across modalities. In particular, revision guidelines helped parents identify and address limitations in AI-generated outputs during the storybook creation process.

Overall, this work contributes to the understanding of parent–AI collaboration in personalized storybook creation and provides implications for the design of future AI-assisted creative systems that support parents in developing multimodal content for children.

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